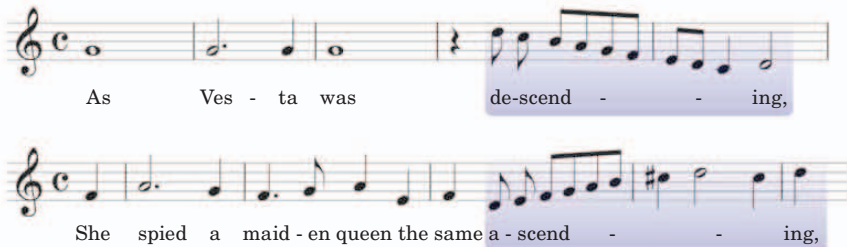


Word-painting

Illustrating a particular word or phrase literally in music is called word-painting. This technique is common in Renaissance and Baroque vocal music (c.1550–1750), especially in madrigals—secular part-songs for several voices. It brings the music to life, not only in the performance, but also visually on the page.



△ Descending

In Thomas Weelkes' madrigal "As Vesta Was From Latmos Hill Descending," rising and falling melodic phrases visually represent the meaning of the words.

Rising melodic phrase representing the word ascending

LOOKING CLOSER

Writing for singers

Some vowel sounds are more difficult to sing than others, especially on a long or high note. For example, on high notes singers prefer to sing the vowels "oo" or "ee." The main singing vowel sounds are:

Ah as in farther

Eh as in let

Ee as in greet

Oh as in phone

Oo as in blue

Accompaniment

Piano and guitar are the most popular instruments for accompanying the voice because they provide chords to underpin the harmony and support the vocal line. Composers try to reflect the sense of the text and meaning of specific words in the accompaniment.

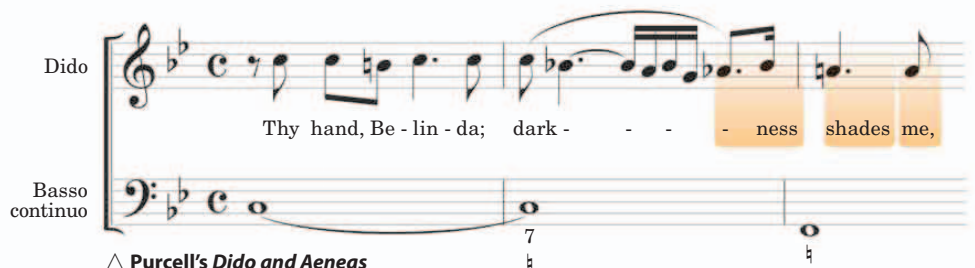
▽ Coloring words

In Schubert's song "Mein!" about a brook, the rippling piano part vividly depicts the watery sounds of a flowing stream.



Recitative

Operas and oratorios use a special kind of musical word setting called recitative. It is a declamatory rather than melodic style, used to move on the story, or when every word of dialogue must be heard clearly.



△ Purcell's *Dido and Aeneas*

In this recitative from *Dido and Aeneas*, the speechlike melodic line is underpinned by simple harmonies improved by the continuo.